

CANDIDATE ADVANI

The BJP finally has a successor and the NDA a prime ministerial candidate. Advani's nomination has consolidated the party as it signals the end of infighting and power play for the top job.

■ **By Priya Sahgal**

It was an idea whose time had come. When BJP announced L.K. Advani as its prime ministerial candidate for the next general elections, it was a unanimous decision. No one fought it, not even his old foe Murli Manohar Joshi who shared the dais when the announcement was made. It was the same Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) that had forced Advani to step down as party chief just two years ago which now pushed for his candidature to lead BJP back to power. A man with a

strong sense of irony the 80-year old may have permitted himself a wry smile had his mouth not been stuffed with so many ladoos.

"I met Vajpayeeji and he said that since his health prevented him from playing an active role in the party, it is better if we nominate Advani," said party president Rajnath Singh. An ailing Atal Bihari Vajpayee and a weak gen next were crucial factors that prompted the saffron leadership to go back to an unfinished chapter in an old story. It was also felt that this was Advani's legitimate right. He is the

tallest leader in not just BJP, but the entire NDA or in Rajnath's words, "the natural choice" after Vajpayee. Yet the announcement, coming right on the eve of the crucial Gujarat elections was not without its share of intrigue. There was speculation that a Narendra Modi win could be a spoiler in the leadership stakes at the Centre and hence the declaration was rushed through. Even the prime minister pitched in and mocked the BJP saying, "Fearing danger from Modi, BJP has crowned Advani."

The announcement itself was planned and executed with a finesse

VAJPAYEE PAST PERFECT

THE ORATOR : A fiery speaker who can sway the masses. He is a visionary who loves the grand gesture but is fuzzy about the details.

NEHRUVIAN ICON: Has often disagreed with the Sangh's hardline. His consensual approach helped him run the first stable non-Congress government.

THE LONER: A good listener but not a great drawing room conversationist. Is moved by poetry, thinks in Hindi. Knows how to deliver the perfect soundbite.

THE PARTY PATRIARCH: Has retired from active politics but will still play an advisory role. Has emerged as the bridge between RSS and Advani.

